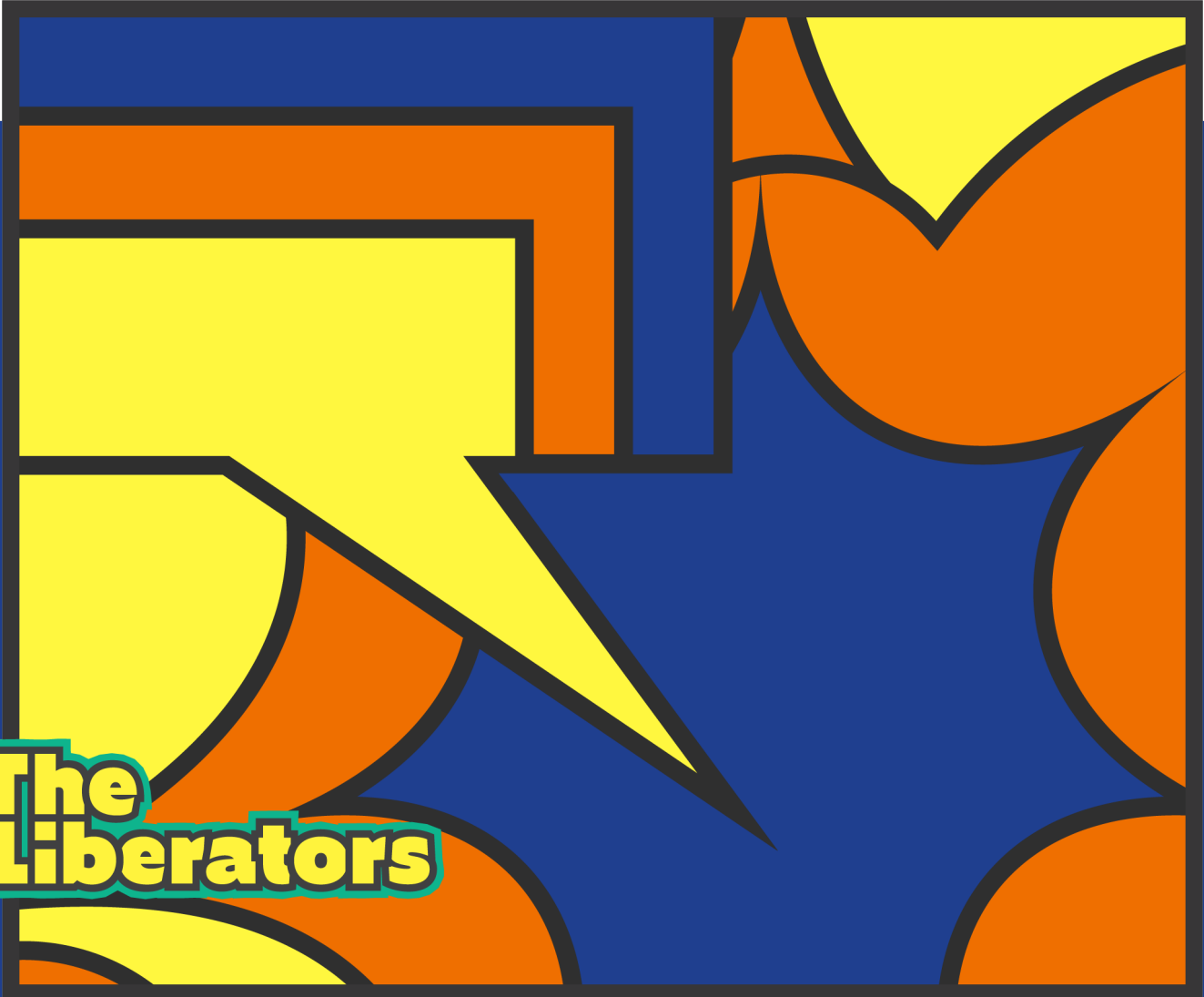


Build Understanding Between Scrum Teams And Management

A do-it-yourself workshop to build support and understanding between management and Scrum teams with "Heard, Seen, Respected"



**The
Liberators**

The Purpose Of This Workshop

Hey there,

We've seen many organizations, and the pattern is usually the same. Scrum teams complain about management, and management complains about Scrum teams. It's no surprise that the relationship between management and teams is often strained.

And while it is unfortunate, it is also not surprising. The role that managers play is quite different for Scrum teams than for departments or regular workgroups. More often than not, we've found that these mutual complaints often stem from a lack of understanding of each other's position and needs.

So we designed this do-it-yourself workshop to create space for people to listen to each other on a personal level. We've consistently found that this lays the groundwork for more productive cooperation between management and teams.

Give this workshop a try, and let us know the results.

Barry & Christiaan

The Liberators



Created by Thea Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Verwijs, Johannes Schartau & Barry Overeem
zombiescrum.org

Flow



Step 1: Opening

 3 min

Step 2: The Worst Possible Outcome With "TRIZ"

  30 min

Step 3: Build Understanding With "Heard, Seen, Respected"

  45 min

Step 4: Identify Next Steps With "Impromptu Networking"

  20 min

Step 5: Closing

 2 min

Total duration

 100 min

Difficulty / Effort



Required Skill



The structure of this workshop takes the strain. The hardest part will be to get the right people into the room.

Impact On Survival



Once people learn how to really listen to each other, everything starts to change.



How To Prepare



Group Size

This string of Liberating Structures is feasible from 8 participants and onward, and takes about 1,5 hours, depending on group size.

Intended Audience

We designed this workshop for one or more Scrum teams and including the managers that shape their immediate environment. In large organizations, this likely includes people from middle management positions; team managers, department managers, and HR managers. But in smaller organizations, we highly recommend including top-level management too. If you're up for it, you can certainly include more people from the environment of Scrum teams.

Virtual Delivery

Liberating Structures work well virtually. Here too, they allow you to unleash and involve everyone. What is exceptionally important, however, is that you have the right tools. Because Liberating Structures are fundamentally about breaking down large-group interactions into smaller groups, you need tools that allow you to create subchannels or breakout rooms easily. [Zoom](#) is ideal for this, but similar features are available in tools like [Teams](#) and [GotoMeeting](#). We also recommend a virtual whiteboard where you can collect shared insights, like [Mural](#), [Miro](#), or [Google Slides](#). Even [Slack](#) can work.

Preparation

- Prepare slides or supporting materials for the various rounds and their invitations.



Step 1: Opening

Start at the scheduled time. People who drop in later can jump in then. We always start our gatherings by simply saying "Hi!", followed by our name. We then explain the purpose and start with the first structure. Superfast!

We've learned that the best way to drain energy is to talk for a long time, to ask everyone to introduce themselves, or to wait for people to drop in.



Step 2: The Worst Possible Outcome With "TRIZ"

The first step in this workshop is to playfully explore how you can guarantee the worst possible working relationship between teams and management. The Liberating Structure [TRIZ](#) is a great way to do this.

Invitation

"When you take a look at the collaboration between Scrum teams and management in this organization, what can we do to guarantee an outcome that is so bad that it will be the topic of a future Netflix documentary that explores damaged relations between teams and management?"

Steps

- **2 min** First individually and in silence, ask everyone to compile a list of all the things they can do, individually or together, to guarantee the worst possible outcome.
- **5 min** Invite people into pairs and into separate breakouts. Ask everyone to share their lists and expand them together. Encourage people to go wild with here; more is better! Even seemingly ridiculous ideas can lead to great insights.
- **3 min** When everyone is back together, or in the main channel, ask: "In silence, go through your list and mark the items that resemble, or are similar to, something we're already doing in this organization".
- **5 min** Invite people into new pairs and move them into separate breakouts. Ask the pairs to share what they recognized and notice patterns.
- **3 min** When everyone is back together, or in the main channel, ask: "Based on the items that you recognized in this group, what should we stop doing?"
- **5 min** Invite people into new pairs and move them into separate breakouts where they can share their insights.
- **5 min** When everyone is back in the main channel, ask everyone to capture their biggest takeaways on a shared workspace. In the meantime, you can pick a few and ask people to explain the ideas behind them.
- **1 min** More likely than not, some groups identified aspects related to listening and understanding each other's needs. This is a great connection to the next step, where the group will be doing just that.

Our Findings

- Don't spoil the twist in TRIZ between the first and second rounds. Doing so will limit creativity and the brutal honesty that makes TRIZ work, as people will already start reflecting on their current situation during the first round;

Resources

- Blogpost: [Stop counterproductive activities and behaviors to make space for innovation with TRIZ](#)



Step 3: Build Understanding With "Heard, Seen, Respected"



How often do you find yourself in a position where you have the uninterrupted attention of another person? Where you have to space to say what you want to say, without feeling rushed or interrupted by their questions? In most organizations, there is rarely an opportunity to really slow down and really listen. It's no wonder that misunderstandings lead to frustrations, and then complaints. The heart of this do-it-yourself workshop is the Liberating Structure [Heard, Seen, Respected](#), which is an excellent structure to share your story and listen to other stories.

Invitation

"Share a story of a time in this organization when you did not feel heard, seen, or respected by management or the Scrum teams. You may not want to pick the most painful one."

Steps

1. **1 min** If you're doing this in-person, invite people to take chairs and form pairs now, mixing management with members from Scrum teams as much as possible. Encourage people to sit (don't stand!) face-to-face and as knee-to-knee as possible. If you're doing this virtually, move pairs into breakouts after step 3.
2. **3 min** Invite everyone to take a moment of individual reflection to remember a time in their work for this organization where they did not feel seen, heard, or respected in this organization by management or the Scrum teams.
3. **3 min** Explain the steps. What's going to happen next is all about listening, without judgment, interrupting, or trying to fix things. One person shares their story, and the other person listens with full attention. In the first round of 15 minutes, both members in each pair take 7-minute turns of interrupted time to share their story. The other person listens with full attention and doesn't interrupt, except with a brief encouragement like "go on" or "what happened next?". Partners do not switch until you – as a facilitator – signal that 7 minutes have passed. It's up to the storyteller to decide how to best use their turn, and if part of that is in silence that's okay.
4. **15 min** Invite people into breakouts if you're doing this virtually. Start the first 7-minute turn. The person whose birthday is closest to today goes first. Signal that it's time to switch rounds after 7 minutes.

5. **5 min** While people remain in their pairs, invite them to share what it was like for them to share this story *and* to listen to the other person.
6. **2 min** If you're doing this in-person, ask the pairs to join another pair and sit together. If you're doing this virtually, merge pairs into one breakout after step 7.
7. **10 min** First individually and in silence, ask people to reflect on the patterns that are revealed by the stories **1 min**, then in their small groups **4 min**. When everyone is back together again, ask the groups to share some of their patterns **5 min**.
8. **5 min** Complete "Heard, Seen Respected" with a shared debrief. Ask: "How can we use Heard, Seen, Respected – or something like it – to address the patterns we identified?"

Our Findings

- For exercises like this, pairs can take a long time to decide who goes first when you leave it to them. So take this responsibility away with rules like: "the person whose birthday is the closest to today", "the person living closest to where we are right now", or "the person with the most visible jewelry".
- When you don't have an even number, you can work with one group of three. They can either self-manage their timebox into 5 minutes each, or one person can volunteer to listen in all rounds.
- Although this Liberating Structure tends to take people out of their comfort zone, at least the first time they experience it, it is also a favorite among people who've done it. Trust in the structure to take the strain.

Resources

- Original post on [Heard, Seen, Respected](#) from LiberatingStructures.com
- Blogpost: [Build Empathy and Understanding with 'Heard, Seen, Respected'](#)





Step 4: Identify Next Steps With "Impromptu Networking"

In this workshop, you explored how (not) to build understanding between management and Scrum teams. The needs of management will not always be aligned with those of the Scrum teams, and vice versa. So in this closing, we'll explore what to hold on to from this workshop. The Liberating Structure [Impromptu Networking](#) is great for this.

Invitation

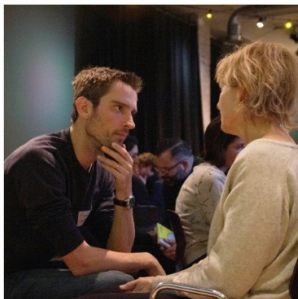
"Now that we're here, how can we continue building mutual support and understanding between management and the Scrum teams in this organization?"

Steps

1. **1 min** First offer the invitation and give everyone a minute to silently get their thinking started about what they noticed.
2. **3 min** Ask everyone to form pairs let them share what they noticed. If you're doing this virtually, assign people to breakout rooms.
3. **6 min** Repeat the previous round twice more. Invite people into new pairs, and let them share their thoughts and observations while noticing patterns.
4. **10 min** When everyone is back together, ask the participants for the most interesting patterns they noticed. Capture them on a shared surface if you want to.

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- Blogpost: [Rapidly share novel ideas and make personal connections with 'Impromptu Networking'](#)



Step 5: Closing

With this workshop, you've explored how and where you can create more understanding between Scrum teams and management. Open and honest communication about needs is the most important here, and this workshop gave the group an opportunity to see what is made possible by that.

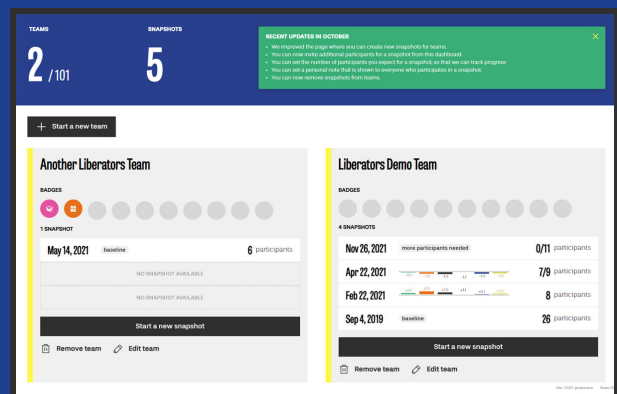
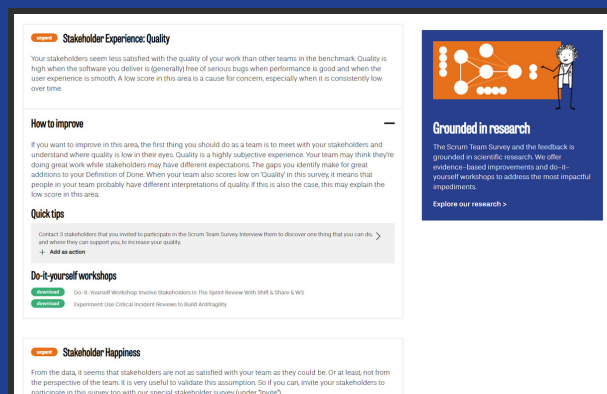
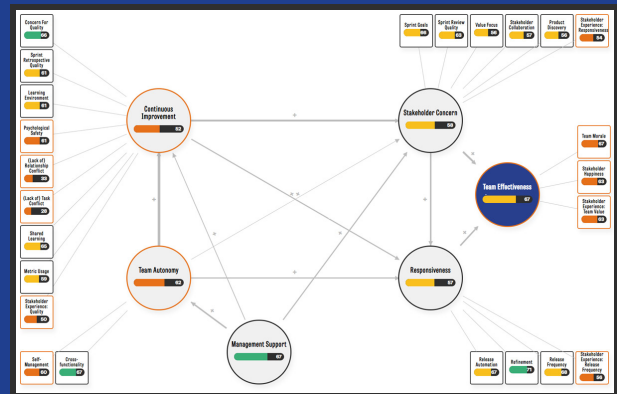
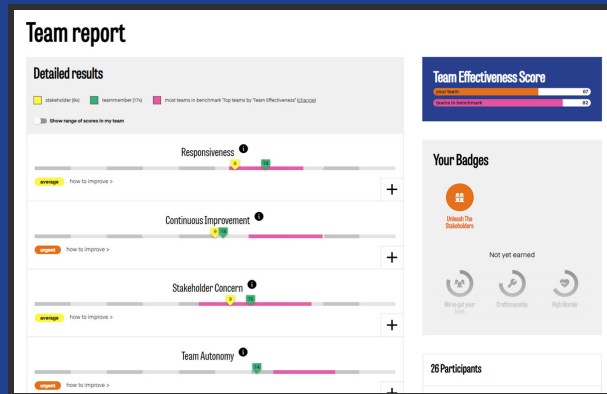
If you've got any questions, comments, or ideas: always feel free to reach out and share them with us.

Let's learn and grow, together!



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	Essential	Liberator
Invite team members & stakeholders	unlimited	unlimited
Quick Tips for your team per topic	3	unlimited
Recommendations to your team	5	unlimited
Compare your team against different benchmarks		✓
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Receive our personal guidance on how to get started		✓
See where your team improves over time with Team Trends		✓
Support our academic research to help more teams		✓
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<https://scrumteamsurvey.org>

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